

STRATEGIC RESEARCH · DE BEERS GROUP · 2025

A Diamond is Forever

The life of a slogan, 1947–2025

On the evolution of the natural diamond's founding narrative and on the terms of its renewal.

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ABOUT THIS RESEARCH

This research was conducted in 2025 for De Beers Group as the strategic foundation of *A Diamond is Forever* (hereafter ADIF), the platform dedicated to the cultural, emotional and symbolic power of natural diamonds. It follows the trajectory of a single sentence written in Philadelphia in 1947 and re-traces the cultural work that sentence accomplished over seven decades. It then examines the conditions under which the line must now operate, from a market divided by laboratory-grown stones to a generation that no longer receives the engagement ring as a given, across three territories whose relationship to the diamond has little in common, and derives from this reading a strategic response built on storytelling understood as cultural transmission.

The brand identity developed alongside this work, its manifesto and tone of voice as well as its visual system, has been deliberately left out of the present document. What remains is the analysis and the strategy.

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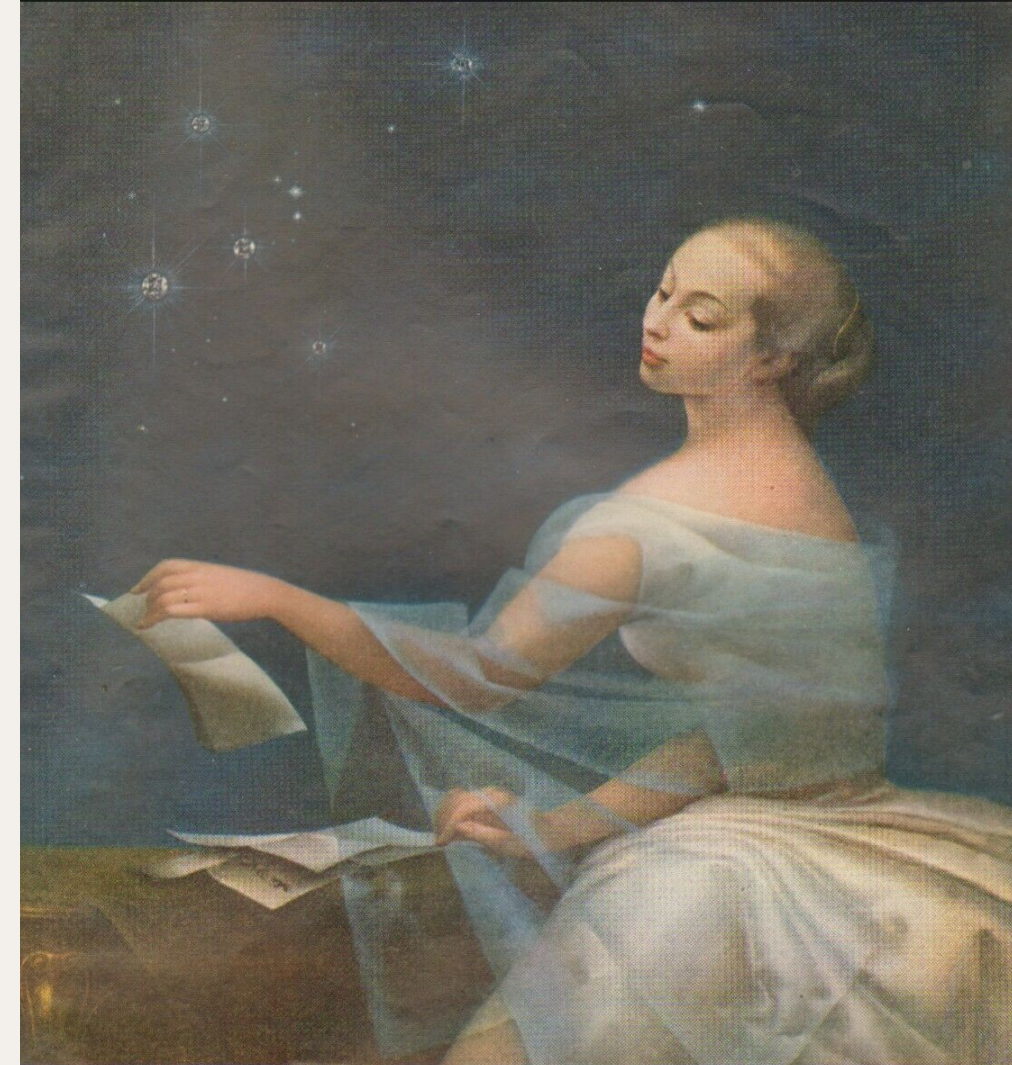
I

Genesis of a slogan

1938–1949

A letter from De Beers, a survey of American households, an antitrust constraint and a copywriter's late-night note: the conditions under which the most successful line in the history of advertising came into being.

"Love's dream written in starlight", N. W. Ayer & Son for De Beers.



The Constellation, Cygnus, the Swan. It is also called the Northern Cross. Painted for the De Beers Collection by Leona Wood

De Beers Consolidated Mines

1/4 carat (25 points) \$90 to \$225
1/2 carat (50 points) \$200 to \$475
1 carat (100 points) \$540 to \$1150
2 carats (200 points) \$1600 to \$3500

Price ranges above are based on quotations by jewelers throughout the country in April, 1956, for their top-grade engagement diamonds (unmounted) in weights indicated. Prices vary with top qualities offered. Exceptionally fine stones are higher priced. Exact weights shown are infrequent. Add tax.



FACTS ABOUT DIAMONDS

Color, cutting and clarity, as well as carat weight, contribute to a diamond's beauty and value. A trusted jeweler is your best adviser. Divided payments can usually be arranged.

LOVE'S DREAM WRITTEN IN STARLIGHT

Alight in the Milky Way, Cygnus, the Swan, is a bearer of dreams. For lovers, through centuries, have mused on his bright stars:

Deep in the earth, long ago, a star as beautiful and timeless was wrought for you and one you love.

Your engagement diamond holds inscribed in sparkling lights the dream of love that lends sweet meaning to the life you share.

It will keep a shining record of your destiny's fulfillment, for you and generations to be, until time's end.

A DIAMOND IS FOREVER

1. *Origin of the slogan*

The slogan “A Diamond is Forever” was created in 1947 by a young copywriter named Frances Gerety, working at the Philadelphia advertising agency N. W. Ayer & Son. The agency had been hired by De Beers in the late 1930s to reinvigorate the diamond market in the United States, which had suffered during the Great Depression. Gerety was tasked with developing a line that would emotionally link diamonds with love and commitment.

Late one night, she jotted down the now-iconic phrase just before going to bed. The next morning, she presented it to her team with the simple justification: “This is what I wrote. It’s not grammatically correct, but it says what I mean.” Despite its simplicity and initial hesitations within the agency, “A Diamond is Forever” was adopted, and it would prove to be one of the most successful advertising slogans in history.¹

2. *The commission*

The commission predates the line by almost a decade. In 1938, a De Beers representative wrote to N. W. Ayer to ask whether “the use of propaganda in various forms” might lift the sale of diamonds in the United States, where demand had been declining since the Depression. The agency’s surveys of consumer attitudes returned an unambiguous picture. Most Americans regarded diamonds as a luxury reserved for the very rich, and women would rather see their fiancés spend on a washing machine or a new car than on an engagement ring. Gerety recalled in 1988 that the ring “was considered just absolutely money down the drain.” The agency nonetheless set itself an ambitious goal, in its own words: “to create a situation where almost every person pledging marriage feels compelled to acquire a diamond engagement ring.”

Because De Beers controlled the world supply of rough diamonds, antitrust law prevented the company from doing business in the United States, a first constraint that shaped everything that followed:

the advertisements could promote neither De Beers nor any jeweller, and they could not even show jewellery. Ayer therefore commissioned paintings from artists such as André Derain and purchased existing works by Dalí and Picasso, placing the stone within the register of art rather than of merchandise. The second constraint was the agency’s own diagnosis, set out in a memo to its client: “Sentiment is essential to your advertising, as it is to your product, for the emotional connotation of the diamond is the one competitive advantage which no other product can claim or dispute.” The diamond would be sold as feeling before it was sold as stone.

3. *The line*

Gerety had joined Ayer in 1943, at a time when women were usually hired to write for women’s products only; the agency had just lost a female copywriter, and De Beers became her main account. For the next twenty-five years she wrote all of the company’s advertisements. Her counterpart in publicity was Dorothy Dignam, who kept in the drawer beneath her typewriter a list of the questions her male colleagues asked her, things she was expected to know as a woman. Neither of them ever married. Their greatest professional achievement, arguably, was to create the emotional attachment to the diamond engagement ring.

Gerety herself recounted the night of 1947 in a 1988 interview with a colleague, Howard Davis. She had just finished a series of advertisements and was headed to bed when she realised she had forgotten the signature line. Exhausted, she said “Dear God, send me a line,” and scribbled something on a slip of paper. When she woke and read what she had written, she thought it was merely acceptable. At the meeting a few hours later, by her account, “Nobody jumped.” The line has nonetheless appeared in every De Beers engagement advertisement since 1948.

¹ J. Courtney Sullivan, “How Diamonds Became Forever”, *The New York Times*, 3 May 2013. Unless otherwise indicated, the account of the Ayer years in this part draws on Sullivan’s article and on Edward Jay Epstein, *The Rise and Fall of Diamonds* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1982).

4. *The machinery of desire*

Dignam's theory was that “the big ones sell the little ones.” She wrote a monthly letter to newspapers describing the diamond jewellery worn by Hollywood actresses and appeared as a guest columnist on the women's pages under the name Diamond Dot Dignam. In the 1950s the agency began lending jewels to socialites and starlets for the Academy Awards and the Kentucky Derby. The campaign succeeded from the start: within two years, the sale of diamonds in the United States had risen by 55 per cent. In its 1951 annual report, Ayer noted that the engagement-ring tradition was growing consistently stronger, and that jewellers now reported “a girl is not engaged unless she has a diamond engagement ring.”

The agency also shaped the vocabulary through which the stone would be judged. The Four C's arose from a surplus of very small stones: buyers had been taught that bigger meant better and showed no interest, so Ayer added a box headed “How to Buy a Diamond” to every advertisement, instructing readers to ask about colour, clarity and cutting, and to “choose a fine stone, and you'll always be proud of it, no matter what its size.” The fourth C stood for carats. In the 1980s, a further series set an arbitrary but authoritative benchmark: “Isn't two months' salary a small price to pay for something that lasts forever?”

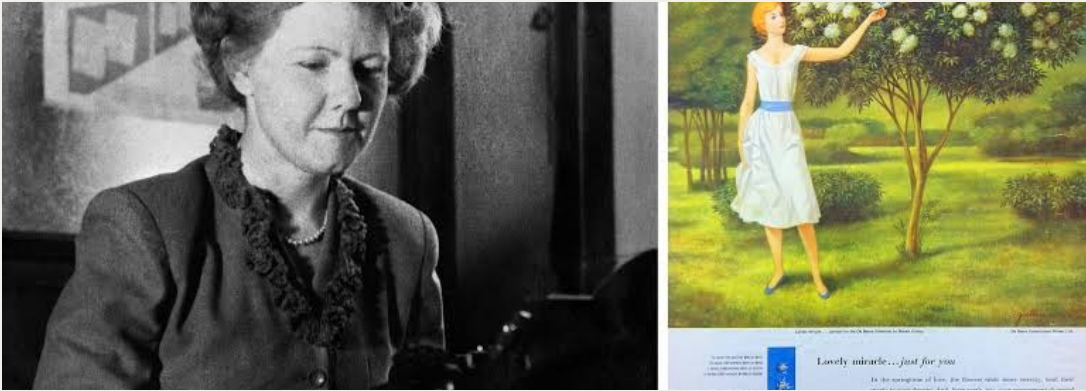
Some attempts at changing cultural attitudes fared less well than others, beginning with an effort to interest men in wearing diamond rings, which produced a couple in pyjamas playing checkers in bed (“She has a mind of her own. She gave me a diamond.”). The “Women of the World, Raise Your Right Hand” campaign of 2003 met with some eye-rolling, although it owed a debt to a 1965 series of Gerety's addressed to “bachelor girls, divorcées, widows, or career women buying on their own,” that part of the market which was “less, or not at all, motivated by copy appeals rooted in love.” Deanne Torbert Dunning, Ayer's first female vice-president on the creative side, wrote the account through the turbulent years of 1968 to 1970, when the women's movement and an anti-establishment mood

pushed the advertisements towards a more casual register: “Yes, you can get married barefoot on a beach, but don't you still want a beautiful ring?”

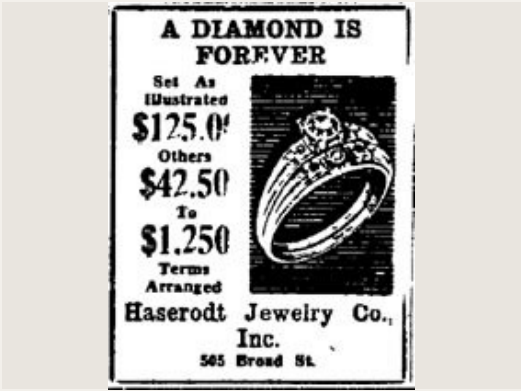
One thing, at least, remained firmly in place: in 1999, two weeks before Gerety died at the age of 83, *Advertising Age* named “A Diamond is Forever” the slogan of the century. By then, and despite a decade and a half of bad press about conflict diamonds and mining conditions, three quarters of American brides wore a diamond engagement ring.²

² Figure from Kenneth Gassman, Jewelry Industry Research Institute, cited in Sullivan (2013).

PLATES · THE AYER CAMPAIGN



Frances Gerety, copywriter at N. W. Ayer & Son, and one of her advertisements for De Beers.



An American jeweller's newspaper advertisement taking up the line.



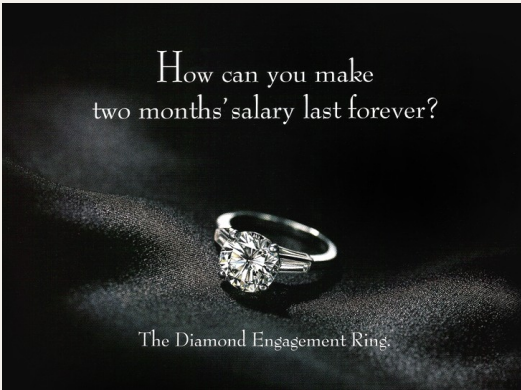
"Magic messenger... to tell your love", N. W. Ayer for De Beers.



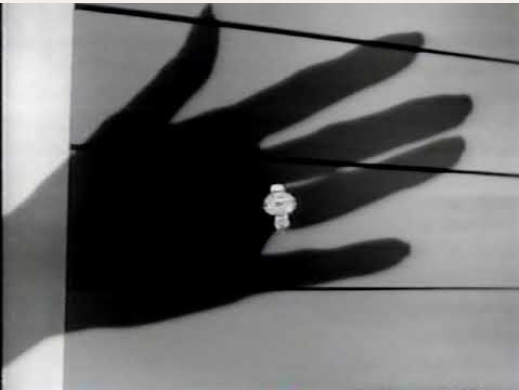
Advertisement by N. W. Ayer for De Beers, with the line in signature.



"Diamonds bespeak an ever-growing love", 1964.



"How can you make two months' salary last forever?"



"Shadows", De Beers television campaign, 1996.

II

From tagline to myth

The cultural work of the slogan

Over the course of the twentieth century, the phrase “A Diamond is Forever” underwent a remarkable transformation, from a clever marketing tagline introduced in 1947 into one of the most enduring cultural symbols of love, commitment and social aspiration. Its legacy lies not only in the words themselves, but in how they reshaped global attitudes toward diamonds, love and ritual.

“Diamonds bespeak an ever-growing love”, N. W. Ayer & Son for De Beers, 1960s.



1. *Diamonds as emotional symbols*

Prior to the mid-twentieth century, diamonds were largely confined to the realm of aristocracy and the ultra-wealthy. De Beers' campaign, spearheaded by N. W. Ayer, ingeniously reframed the diamond from a mere status object into an emotional talisman, intimately tied to the narrative of romantic love. The diamond engagement ring was positioned as a necessary act of devotion, a visual proof of enduring affection. The campaign's real breakthrough lay in its democratisation of luxury: by targeting the American middle class, it successfully implanted the idea that love should be marked by a diamond, regardless of one's socioeconomic standing.

Through strategic placements in Hollywood films, women's magazines and school curricula (De Beers funded educational materials promoting diamond symbolism), the diamond ring became less an accessory than a rite of passage. By the 1970s, over 80 per cent of American brides received a diamond engagement ring, an astonishing cultural shift that can be directly attributed to the long-running impact of the campaign.

2. *Diamonds as timeless*

The brilliance of the slogan lies not only in its emotional resonance, but in its economic implications. The phrase "A Diamond is Forever" did more than link love to a precious stone; it positioned the diamond as an object of eternity, immutable, untouchable, unresellable. By suggesting that the diamond represents a love that never fades, the slogan subtly discouraged second-hand resale, bolstering the idea of scarcity and value retention.

This had a dual function: it protected the mystique of the diamond while sustaining De Beers' control over the global supply and pricing structure. In reality, diamonds are not rare geologically, but the artificial limitation of supply, combined with the emotional weight of the slogan, made them feel irreplaceable. As Edward Jay Epstein noted in his investigative work *The Rise and Fall of Diamonds*, the campaign's genius lay in selling not a product but a feeling.³ The idea that a diamond could "forever" encapsulate

the emotions of a moment made it immune to trends, and protected its monetary and symbolic value.

3. *Global expansion and cultural reframing*

The success of the campaign in the United States inspired De Beers to expand its emotional narrative globally. In post-war Japan, for instance, the idea of diamond engagement rings was virtually non-existent. But through culturally sensitive marketing that emphasised harmony, loyalty and family values rather than overt romance, De Beers introduced the Western engagement ritual as a desirable modern practice. By the 1980s, after years of persistent advertising and narrative building, more than 60 per cent of Japanese brides wore diamond rings, a profound cultural transformation engineered almost entirely through storytelling.

Similar strategies were applied in countries like China, India and Brazil, always tailoring the narrative to resonate with local values while maintaining the universal idea: that a diamond is the natural expression of love.

4. *Recognition and enduring legacy*

The phrase's influence extended beyond marketing into the cultural canon. In 1999, *Advertising Age* named "A Diamond is Forever" the greatest advertising slogan of the twentieth century, an accolade that recognised not just its poetic simplicity, but its unmatched impact on consumer behaviour and emotional norms.

Today, the slogan persists in collective consciousness, even among those sceptical of marriage or traditional luxury. It remains a symbol of permanence in a world of change, a mythology forged not in antiquity, but in the boardrooms of Madison Avenue.

³ Edward Jay Epstein, *The Rise and Fall of Diamonds: The Shattering of a Brilliant Illusion* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1982); see also his essay "Have You Ever Tried to Sell a Diamond?", *The Atlantic*, February 1982.

III

The slogan in the twenty-first century

Contemporary use and legacy

De Beers continues to use “A Diamond is Forever” as a central element of its brand identity. Between 2024 and 2025 the line was reasserted in two campaigns and sharpened against laboratory-grown stones, while the promise it carries was extended to the provenance of the stone itself.



1. Reasserting the slogan

In November 2024, De Beers launched a major campaign titled *Forever Present*, reviving the historic line while subtly reframing it for a broader audience. This campaign did not solely target romantic couples, but also celebrated emotional connections across generations, friendships and self-empowerment. By doing so, De Beers reaffirmed the timeless nature of diamonds, not just as romantic symbols but as markers of enduring emotional moments.

This reintroduction was a deliberate strategic pivot aimed at re-engaging younger demographics, particularly Millennials and Gen Z, who may be more sceptical of traditional luxury codes or more drawn to lab-grown alternatives. As noted in the *Rapaport Diamond Report* of November 2024, the campaign was an attempt to reposition the diamond as a meaningful, natural object amid increasing market saturation and competition from synthetics.⁴

2. Response to market challenges

The slogan's message has gained renewed significance as De Beers responds to growing challenges in the industry, particularly the rise of lab-grown diamonds. With lab-created stones now capturing a substantial share of the market, especially in the United States, De Beers has sharpened its messaging around permanence, authenticity and emotional investment.

In October 2024, the *Worth the Wait* campaign, developed with Signet Jewelers, directly highlighted the difference between mined and lab-grown diamonds, not merely in terms of origin, but in terms of meaning and emotional gravity: the slow formation of a natural stone was set against the slow maturation of a relationship.⁵ The slogan thus serves not only as a romantic proposition, but also as a philosophical stance: a declaration of enduring value against the ephemeral or the artificial. In May 2025, De Beers an-

nounced the closure of Lightbox, its lab-grown jewellery brand, to refocus exclusively on natural diamonds, reinforcing the long-term strategy embedded in the 1947 line.⁶

3. Cultural and ethical adaptation

The slogan has also evolved in response to broader cultural and ethical pressures. Since the late 1990s, scrutiny over conflict diamonds prompted De Beers to invest in traceability and transparency. Initiatives such as the Kimberley Process, the launch of the Forevermark brand and, more recently, the Tracr blockchain platform were introduced to ensure the ethical provenance of its diamonds.

These efforts do not explicitly reference the slogan, but they are deeply tied to its underlying promise of permanence and trust. The diamond, if it is to last forever, must also be responsibly sourced, and the brand has worked to align its legacy with contemporary expectations around environmental and social governance.

4. The slogan as a philosophy

More than an advertising phrase, “A Diamond is Forever” now operates as a kind of brand philosophy, a shorthand for emotional continuity, memory and commitment. De Beers has begun to frame the diamond not only as a romantic object but as a timeless vessel of meaning, capable of holding stories across generations. This shift mirrors broader changes in the luxury industry, where storytelling and heritage are increasingly used to create emotional resonance and brand differentiation.

Today, “A Diamond is Forever” can be read as a bridge between eras. It recalls post-war consumer optimism, but it is being recalibrated to speak to new values: care, authenticity, mindfulness and origin. It holds its place not because of nostalgia, but because it continues to evolve with the times.

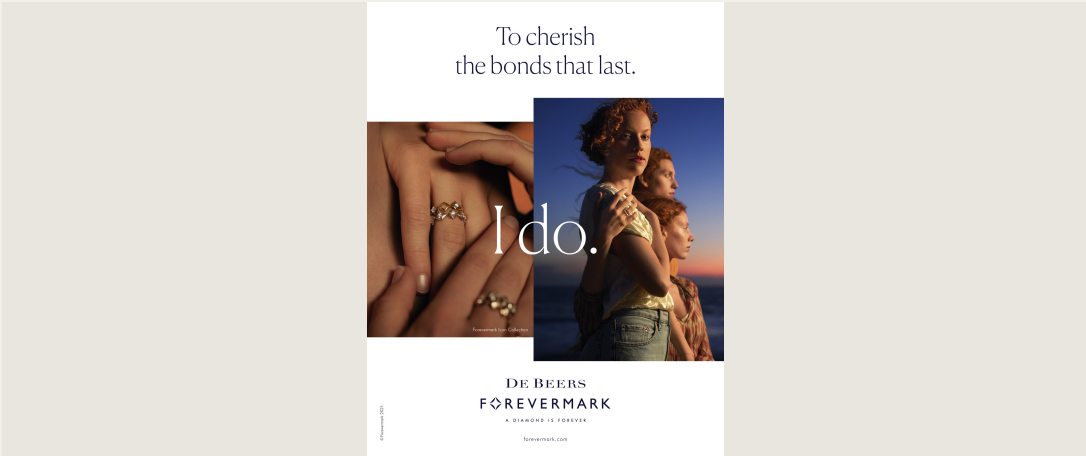
⁴ *Rapaport Diamond Report*, November 2024.

⁵ Signet Jewelers and De Beers Group, “Worth the Wait”, launched 15 October 2024 in the United States.

⁶ *The Times*, May 2025; De Beers Group, announcement of 8 May 2025.



Forever Present, De Beers, 2024: the line extended to friendship and self.



De Beers Forevermark, “To cherish the bonds that last”.



Worth the Wait, Signet Jewelers and De Beers, October 2024.



A Diamond is Forever.

IV

A new era

Four structural challenges

The erosion of aspiration among younger generations, the disruption of laboratory-grown diamonds, the gap between sustainability efforts and their perception, and the fragmentation of the narrative itself. Each is examined here in its context and in its consequences.



1. *New generations: disconnection from traditional diamond values*

CONTEXT. De Beers' iconic legacy, rooted in permanence, marriage, tradition and social status, no longer resonates with younger generations. Millennials and Gen Z are driven by authenticity, ethical consciousness, individuality and emotional meaning. The old narrative of "A Diamond is Forever" feels increasingly irrelevant or culturally imposed.

KEY PROBLEMS.

- **Symbolic fatigue.** The diamond is no longer seen as the ultimate sign of love or success; personal narratives now carry more weight than societal conventions.
- **Ethical awareness.** Young consumers want brands to stand for something: values, transparency and purpose.
- **Competing desires.** Flexibility, experiences and self-expression often take precedence over traditional luxury purchases such as natural diamond jewellery.

RESULTING IMPACT. De Beers' storytelling risks becoming nostalgic rather than aspirational, with a message disconnected from the life choices and emotional landscapes of its future customer base.

2. *Lab-grown diamonds: market disruption and strategic contradiction*

CONTEXT. Lab-grown diamonds (LGDs) have become a dominant force in the industry. They are affordable, technically identical to natural diamonds, and increasingly positioned as an ethical or sustainable alternative. In response, De Beers launched Lightbox in 2018, offering lab-grown diamonds

explicitly as non-romantic "fashion accessories"; the move introduced deep brand tensions, which the closure of the brand in 2025 has since acknowledged.

KEY PROBLEMS.

- **Erosion of rarity.** The core value of a natural diamond lies in its geological formation over billions of years. Lab-grown diamonds, produced industrially in weeks, undermine this by offering visual parity at a much lower price.
- **Price collapse.** Lab-grown prices have dropped by over 80 per cent in five years. Even De Beers had to reduce Lightbox prices, reinforcing the idea that diamonds, as a category, are unstable in value.
- **Internal contradiction.** De Beers promotes natural diamonds as eternal, rare and symbolic, while having sold lab-grown diamonds that contradict those very claims.
- **Consumer confusion.** The presence of both offerings within the same corporate house undermined the clarity of messaging and weakened the emotional distinction between lab-grown and natural.

RESULTING IMPACT. De Beers' leadership in diamond storytelling is being challenged not only externally but from within, as the company struggles to hold a coherent position in a bifurcated market.

3. *Sustainability and traceability: expectation versus communication gap*

CONTEXT. Sustainability, ethical sourcing and full traceability have become non-negotiable expectations for many younger consumers, especially for high-value goods. De Beers has invested in traceability (Tracr) and in large-scale environmental and social programmes (Building Forever). Yet these efforts remain largely technical and invisible to the public.

KEY PROBLEMS.

- **Low visibility.** Most consumers are unaware of De Beers' traceability programmes or conservation efforts.
- **Emotional disconnect.** The technical language of blockchain or net-zero mining goals lacks symbolic or cultural resonance.
- **Competitor advantage.** Emerging brands with simple, emotionally compelling ethical stories ("conflict-free", "lab-grown = clean") have captured the public imagination.
- **Credibility gap.** De Beers, as a mining group, still faces the legacy of environmental concerns and associations with conflict zones, despite having taken measurable steps toward ethical transformation.

RESULTING IMPACT. There is a widening gap between what the brand is doing and what the consumer perceives, weakening De Beers' ability to assert leadership in the sustainability discourse.

4. Crisis of identity and storytelling: fragmentation and loss of authority

CONTEXT. De Beers once shaped the global myth of the diamond, a powerful cultural and emotional construct. Today, its narrative is fragmented across different brand arms (De Beers Jewellers, Forevermark, Lightbox), with no unifying emotional throughline.

KEY PROBLEMS.

- **Narrative dilution.** Each sub-brand carries its own tone, purpose and market strategy, creating confusion rather than synergy.
- **Symbolic drift.** De Beers' myth-making power has weakened. Newer voices (Tiffany, Cartier, niche direct-to-consumer brands) are now shaping the cultural meaning of diamonds, often with more agility and relevance.

- **Unresolved tension.** De Beers is caught between luxury heritage and industrial innovation, ritual and fashion, natural and lab-grown, without a clearly defined symbolic framework.
- **Cultural silence.** The brand has not reasserted a modern mythology that responds to today's world, one that can speak to identity, transformation, ritual or love in contemporary terms.

RESULTING IMPACT. De Beers faces not just a marketing challenge, but an ontological one: what is the cultural purpose of a natural diamond in a world that questions eternity, perfection and status?

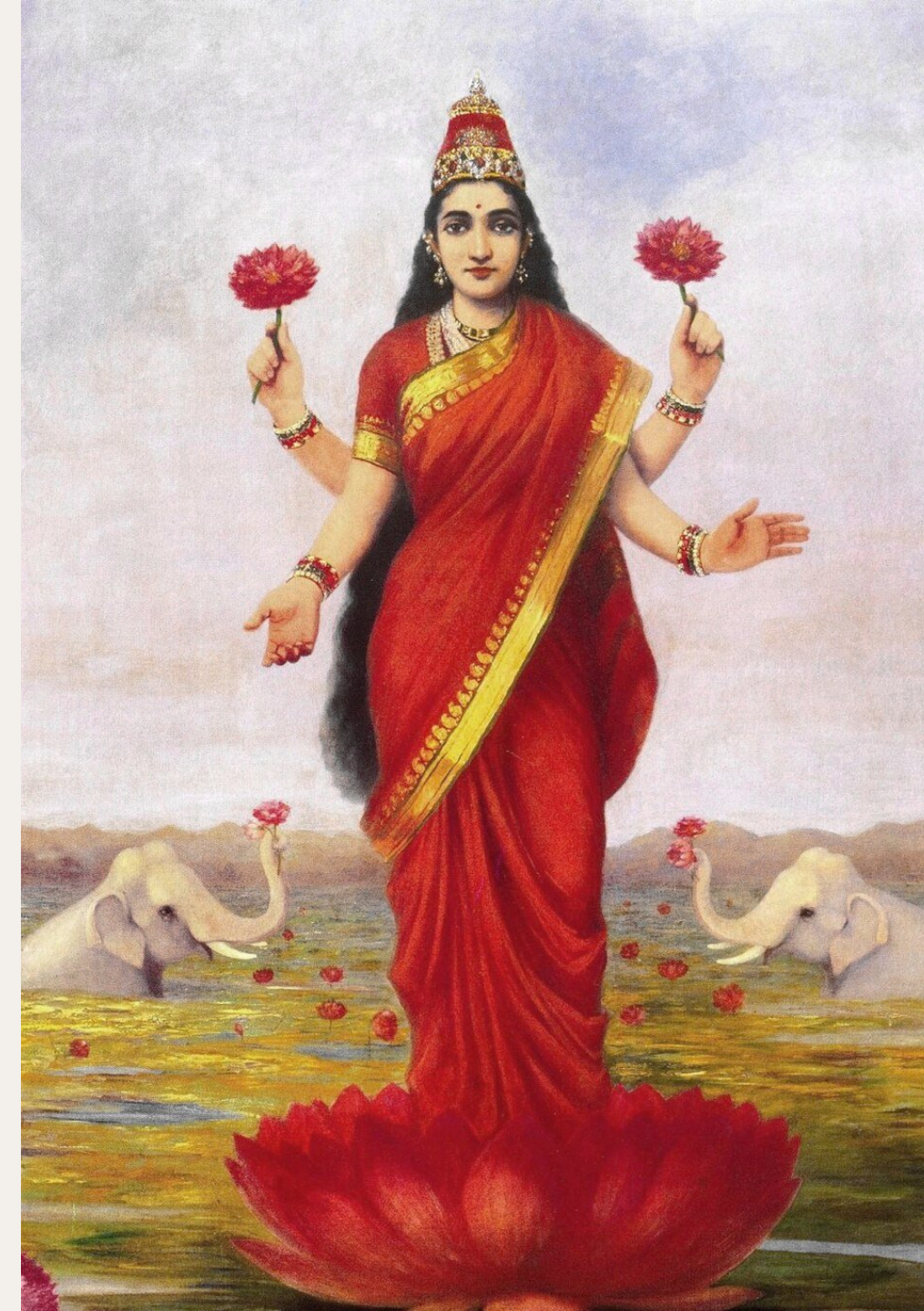
V

Three territories, different challenges

United States · India · China

The United States remains De Beers' largest and most historically profitable market, accounting for 45 to 50 per cent of global diamond jewellery sales, and also its most saturated, disrupted and symbolically unstable one. India represents one of the fastest-growing diamond markets globally, driven by a young, aspirational middle class and a long-standing love for precious materials, yet defined by deep symbolic tensions between tradition and modernity, price sensitivity and status, gold and diamond. China was, until 2019, the second-largest diamond jewellery market in the world; post-pandemic cultural shifts, a slowing economy and changes in consumer sentiment have since created a strategic standstill, marked by insecurity, pragmatism and a re-evaluation of luxury.

Lakshmi, goddess of wealth and fortune, chromolithograph after Raja Ravi Varma.



I. UNITED STATES

Market of disruption and reframing

KEY CHALLENGES

1. GENERATIONAL SHIFT IN VALUES

Younger generations are reshaping what luxury, love and identity mean. The idea of a diamond as a mandatory symbol of marriage or commitment is no longer taken for granted. Marriage rates in the United States have declined significantly over the past two decades, with 40 per cent of young adults aged 25 to 34 remaining unmarried as of 2023.⁷ Emotional purchases are now centred on personal meaning, milestones or self-expression, which need not coincide with romantic or socially prescribed moments. Luxury is increasingly defined by purpose, sustainability and individuality, rather than by status display.

2. LAB-GROWN DIAMOND DISRUPTION

The United States has become the epicentre of the lab-grown boom. As of 2024, over half of American engagement rings feature a lab-grown centre stone.⁸ Consumers perceive these stones as visually identical, more affordable and ethically superior. De Beers' launch of Lightbox as a non-symbolic lab-grown product failed to prevent consumer migration toward lab-grown diamonds for core moments.

3. SUSTAINABILITY AND TRACEABILITY EXPECTATIONS

Ethics and environmental impact are non-negotiable for younger American luxury buyers. Despite initiatives such as Tracr and Building Forever, De Beers is still seen as a traditional mining house

rather than as an ethical visionary. Brands like Brilliant Earth and VRAI have captured the ethical narrative more effectively, using simple, emotionally resonant claims (“conflict-free”, “zero carbon”).

4. NARRATIVE FATIGUE AND FRAGMENTED BRAND PRESENCE

The famous tagline risks feeling fossilised without cultural reinvention. Multiple sub-brands (Forevermark, De Beers Jewellers, Lightbox) create brand dilution, competitors increasingly dominate social, digital and cultural relevance, and De Beers is absent from the lifestyle and values-based conversations shaping luxury today.

⁷ U.S. Census Bureau, *America's Families and Living Arrangements*, 2023.

⁸ The Knot, *2024 Real Weddings Study*; JCK News; Bain & Company, *Global Diamond Industry* reports.

I. UNITED STATES

STRENGTHS

- Largest diamond jewellery market globally
 - Strong legacy of “A Diamond is Forever”
 - High per-capita luxury spend
 - Existing brand recognition
 - Mature retail and certification infrastructure
-

OPPORTUNITIES

- Reframe diamonds as personal milestones, beyond romance
 - Emphasise natural rarity and the deep-time narrative
 - Lead ethical luxury through visible sustainability storytelling
 - Build new rituals through creative community partnerships
 - Cultural resurgence of symbolic, emotional luxury
-

STRATEGIC IMPLICATION

Reposition diamonds as emotionally rich, personally meaningful objects across life stages, beyond romance alone. Reclaim natural rarity through deep-time storytelling: geology, cosmic origin, human tradition. Reignite cultural participation through storytelling carried by artists, philosophers, designers and scientists, and no longer by marketing alone.

WEAKNESSES

- Brand narrative fatigue
 - Fragmented brand architecture (Lightbox, Forevermark, Jewellers)
 - Internal contradiction: natural versus lab-grown
 - Weak presence in cultural and lifestyle conversations
 - Lagging digital storytelling relevance
-

THREATS

- Lab-grown diamonds dominate the engagement-ring market
 - Changing relationship and marriage norms
 - Ethical perception gap versus direct-to-consumer competitors
 - Decline in trust in institutional brands
 - Rising preference for self-gifting and experiential luxury
-

II. INDIA

Market of aspiration and contradiction

KEY CHALLENGES

1. GOLD'S DOMINANCE IN SYMBOLIC AND RITUAL VALUE

Gold remains unrivalled in religious, familial and matrimonial contexts. It is linked to Lakshmi, goddess of wealth and fortune, and regarded as an auspicious, intergenerational asset. Diamonds are still perceived by many as Western, modern and secondary to gold in weddings and family heritage, and rural and Tier II–III markets continue to favour gold heavily in terms of cultural significance.

2. PRICE SENSITIVITY AND LAB-GROWN INTRUSION

India is highly value-conscious, even in luxury segments. Lab-grown diamonds have entered the Indian bridal market, particularly among younger urban couples looking for size and brilliance at lower prices. Brands like Limelight and Divine Solitaire are introducing lab-grown stones with storytelling that mimics traditional natural-diamond branding, blurring the lines for consumers.

3. TRUST AND A FRAGMENTED RETAIL LANDSCAPE

Despite economic growth, the jewellery market remains highly fragmented and informal. Consumers are wary of diamond authenticity and often lack access to certification or origin guarantees. De Beers must overcome low trust and build authority through traceability, brand trust and emotional storytelling.

4. THE EMERGING IDENTITY OF THE MODERN INDIAN BUYER

A new generation is emerging: financially independent, globally exposed and culturally hybrid. These consumers seek personal expression and luxury that aligns with ethical and aspirational values. But

they also want cultural rootedness, which De Beers has not fully addressed in its India-facing narrative.

II. INDIA

STRENGTHS

- Rapidly growing middle and upper class
- Strong historical connection to precious stones
- Increasing bridal diamond adoption in urban areas
- Deep appreciation of luxury and beauty
- Cultural storytelling traditions aligned with symbolic value

OPPORTUNITIES

- Embed natural diamonds in Indian symbolism and legacy
- Educate on geological rarity and ethical sourcing
- Build emotional connection through cultural storytelling
- Leverage spiritual themes: cosmos, purity, light
- Use bridal aspirations to anchor meaning

STRATEGIC
IMPLICATION

Anchor diamonds in Indian cosmology, symbolism and legacy, as bearers of timeless beauty and meaning rather than as Western status symbols. Promote natural rarity as spiritual rarity: formed by the Earth, carrying cosmic time, tied to personal transformation. Build trust and legitimacy through storytelling, certification and emotional resonance, well beyond technical assurances.

WEAKNESSES

- Gold's dominance in rituals and inheritance
- Diamond seen as modern but not sacred
- High price sensitivity
- Low consumer trust in diamond certification
- Fragmented retail and informal sales channels

THREATS

- Lab-grown diamonds entering bridal and fashion segments
- Local brands gaining ground in value-based messaging
- Regulatory unpredictability in luxury imports
- Urban–rural cultural divide in diamond literacy
- Perception of diamonds as Western or non-essential

III. CHINA

Market of transition and silent hesitation

KEY CHALLENGES

1. DECLINE OF TRADITIONAL ROMANTIC DIAMOND CONSUMPTION

Engagement and marriage rates in China have declined sharply. Between 2013 and 2023, marriage registrations dropped by more than 40 per cent.⁹ The idea of a diamond ring as a marker of commitment is not deeply rooted in Chinese culture and is increasingly seen as unnecessary or foreign.

2. LUXURY PRAGMATISM AND ECONOMIC UNCERTAINTY

Post-pandemic Chinese consumers, especially Gen Z, are more cautious, pragmatic and savings-oriented. The “she economy” of independent female consumers is now defined more by control and empowerment than by traditional romantic aspiration. De Beers faces competition not just from lab-grown stones but from gold, technology, experiences and self-investment. Lab-grown diamonds are present but not dominant; the challenge is one of relevance rather than of substitution.

3. DIGITAL AND SOCIAL DISCONNECT

De Beers has a limited cultural and social footprint in Chinese digital ecosystems. Platforms like Xiaohongshu, WeChat and Douyin shape aspirational behaviour and storytelling, spaces where De Beers is largely absent or underperforming, while direct-to-consumer brands and local influencers prove more agile and emotionally attuned.

4. CULTURAL REVALUATION OF MEANING

Chinese consumers, particularly urban women, are shifting toward self-expression, minimalism and inner value. The diamond risks being seen as a relic of outdated status narratives unless reframed. There is also growing nationalist sentiment in favour of Chinese brands and symbols of local pride.

⁹ National Bureau of Statistics of China, marriage registrations 2013–2023.

III. CHINA

STRENGTHS

- High cultural respect for natural materials and craftsmanship
- Sophisticated digital commerce and storytelling platforms
- History of valuing rare, symbolic objects (jade, silk, gold)
- Growing independent female luxury market
- Existing awareness of De Beers as a global prestige brand

OPPORTUNITIES

- Reposition the diamond as a symbol of self-empowerment
- Infuse storytelling with Taoist and Buddhist, poetic and cosmic themes
- Emphasise natural formation and harmony with time
- Build credibility via partnerships with local cultural figures
- Leverage Douyin and Xiaohongshu for immersive content

STRATEGIC
IMPLICATION

Reposition natural diamonds as timeless objects of self-possession and transformation, released from romantic obligation. Embody Chinese cultural symbolism subtly: jade metaphors, Taoist and Buddhist cycles, cosmic harmony. Invest in culturally rooted, emotionally resonant digital storytelling, through partnerships with artists, writers and philosophers who speak the Chinese visual and symbolic language.

WEAKNESSES

- Declining marriage and engagement rates
- Low cultural embedding of diamonds in traditional rituals
- Weak brand visibility in local digital and influencer spaces
- Slower post-pandemic economic recovery
- National preference shifting toward domestic brands

THREATS

- Economic caution among Gen Z and urban consumers
- Rising nationalism and preference for Chinese heritage brands
- Lab-grown alternatives slowly gaining visibility
- Shift from material luxury to wellness, experience and technology
- Cultural disconnect if messaging feels Western or imposed

VI

The strategic response

Storytelling as cultural transmission

To rebuild trust, meaning and desire around the natural diamond, the strategy returns to the oldest communication system humans have created, and sets out a journey, a discourse, a community, its storytellers and its rituals.

Gathering around the fire.



1. *Why storytelling lies at the heart of the new strategy*

To ensure the long-term cultural relevance of *A Diamond is Forever*, we must respond to four major challenges facing the natural diamond industry: the erosion of aspiration, the rise of lab-grown alternatives, the shifting expectations of younger generations, and a fragmented global narrative that no longer resonates across cultures. Our solution is not a campaign. It is a cultural reset. To rebuild trust, meaning and desire around the natural diamond, we must return to the most powerful and enduring communication system humans have ever created: storytelling.

This is not metaphor. It is rooted in anthropology and neuroscience. Over 40,000 years ago, the first *Homo sapiens* began gathering around firelit spaces, caves, shelters, early sanctuaries, to tell stories. These were not entertainment. They were ritual acts: a way of transmitting knowledge, beliefs, identity and shared values. These symbolic narratives shaped everything from social cohesion to moral codes. Mircea Eliade wrote that, for traditional man, myth is not fiction but a true history of what happened at the beginning of time, and one that continues to shape the present.¹⁰

Luxury works the same way. People do not buy products. They buy symbols, materials infused with emotion, myth and memory. This is why *A Diamond is Forever* must no longer speak as a brand broadcasting messages, but as a space where stories are told and retold, stories that reconnect us to the essence of the natural diamond.

We propose to rebuild a digital ritual space, the ADIF platform, inspired by the original function of the cave: a protected, symbolic gathering place. It will be animated by a carefully selected group of storytellers: gemmologists, geologists, designers, philosophers, artists, historians. Each will act not as a spokesperson, but as a guide, reactivating the emotional, historical and symbolic depth of the diamond. These storytellers will speak to audiences across the United States, India and China, not through standardised content, but through ritualised, recurring narratives rooted in local culture and

global imagination. They will answer the deep human questions that diamonds have always symbolised: Where do we come from? What do we pass on? What is precious? What endures?

By doing so, we aim to bring together a new community of brand advocates, not passive followers but participants in a shared cultural meaning. A constellation of voices, connected not by product but by purpose. This is not just marketing. It is cultural transmission. It is what diamonds, and stories, have always done.

2. *The transformation journey: from misconception to cultural advocacy*

Within the new strategy, the objective is not simply to generate conversion, but to foster a deep cultural shift. This journey is built on the logic of initiatory storytelling, anthropological models of symbolic transmission and emotionally anchored consumer behaviour. It serves as our most powerful response to the four critical threats facing the natural diamond category.

1 STARTING POINT: A DISTANT OR SCEPTICAL GAZE

The journey begins with a consumer, often from the younger generation, who holds preconceived notions: “Diamonds are overpriced.” “Lab-grown is the same but cheaper.” “Luxury is outdated or inauthentic.” There is no hostility, but a disconnect: diamonds are viewed as irrelevant, commodified or untrustworthy.

2 THE POINT OF ENCOUNTER: INITIAL EXPOSURE TO THE ADIF UNIVERSE

Through search-based discovery, social storytelling or cultural content, the consumer stumbles upon a different tone. It might be a question that opens a symbolic door (“What is a diamond, really?”), a voice that speaks with gravity rather than persuasion, a visual anchored in timelessness rather than trend. This content is not tactical. It is mythic in tone and structure. It triggers curiosity.

¹⁰ Mircea Eliade, *Myth and Reality*, trans. Willard R. Trask (New York: Harper & Row, 1963).

3 THE TURNING POINT: ENCOUNTER WITH THE GUIDE-STORYTELLER

Here, the consumer meets a voice, a trusted guide. This may be a gemmologist, an artist, a designer, a geologist, a philosopher, but always someone deeply rooted in their field and emotionally connected to the material. This is not influencer marketing. This is ritual transmission. The guide does not explain diamonds. They reveal them, as time, as memory, as meaning. The consumer listens. And for the first time, they feel something.

4 IMMERSION: EXPLORING THE SYMBOLIC SPACE

Now that trust has been established, the consumer chooses to stay. They begin exploring the ADIF ecosystem: a story series, an editorial essay, a film, a digital event, a cultural archive. The tone is never didactic. It is layered, poetic and true. The diamond is no longer a product. It is a vessel of permanence.

5 RITUAL: RETURNING TO THE SOURCE

The consumer becomes a participant. They attend recurring storytelling moments, live or asynchronous, and begin to recognise faces, voices, language. They engage with the same storyteller more than once. This repetition is key. In ritual theory, meaning is not produced by novelty, but by recurrence. Trust becomes belonging. Emotion becomes memory.

6 ADVOCACY: EMERGENCE OF A NEW VOICE

At this stage, the consumer is no longer merely informed; they are transformed. They defend natural diamonds in conversations, share content with intention, correct misconceptions, and use the language of ADIF: time, ritual, memory, origin, transmission. They have become a carrier of meaning, a new node in the living network.

7 THE CULTURAL LOOP: SYMBOLIC TRANSMISSION

The final state is not an endpoint, but a return. The individual has moved from scepticism to initiation, from distance to embodiment, from silence to voice. And they now bring others into the space. This is not conversion. It is cultural continuity, activated through symbolic storytelling and sustained through ritual digital engagement.

This is the power of storytelling when it is treated not as content, but as transmission. The story of the diamond does not need to be reinvented. It needs to be retold, in the right voice, in the right place, with the right cadence. That is the mission of A Diamond is Forever: not to dominate attention, but to create a cultural gravity strong enough to make people stop, listen and believe again.

3. A new discourse: dream, magic and meaning

Reinjecting dream, magic and meaning into the narrative of natural diamonds answers, axis by axis, what the category has lost.

DREAM: REAWAKENING THE IMAGINATION

The diamond was once a symbol of human aspiration, of love, transcendence and the sublime. Today, that emotional charge has faded. In an age saturated with information, immediacy and utility, younger generations crave emotionally evocative narratives that take them beyond the rational and into the poetic.

- **It counteracts commoditisation.** Lab-grown diamonds may be visually perfect, but they lack aura. Reintroducing reverie restores a sense of emotional depth and mystery to the natural diamond.
- **It restores value beyond price.** Consumers are willing to invest in what moves them. Dream invites desire, projection and long-term attachment, all of which justify the symbolic and financial value of a natural diamond.
- **It elevates the brand.** Dream is the language of luxury. By tapping into imagination, De Beers can restore its mythic voice and reconnect with a form of storytelling that speaks not just to the consumer, but to the collective unconscious.

MAGIC: RECLAIMING THE SENSE OF THE EXTRAORDINARY

A natural diamond is a geological miracle, formed over billions of years, shaped by immense forces, and born of the depths of the Earth. This origin story is inherently magical, yet it has been flattened by technical discourse and pricing charts.

- **It differentiates from lab-grown.** While lab-grown diamonds can replicate clarity and brilliance, they cannot reproduce origin. Natural diamonds are singular and unrepeatable, and that uniqueness is inherently magical.
- **It speaks to the sacred.** Diamonds once held talismanic or protective power in many cultures. By reinvoking the sacred dimension, time, cosmos, ritual, De Beers can reconnect the object with deeper human instincts.
- **It replaces the rational with the ritual.** Consumers today do not need diamonds. But they may want them if the object becomes once again a vessel for emotion, transformation or ceremony.

MEANING: RESTORING ETHICAL, EMOTIONAL AND SYMBOLIC DEPTH

Today's luxury is no longer about status alone; it must stand for something. Meaning is what allows a product to transcend materiality and become a bearer of values, stories and identity.

- **It bridges generations.** Meaning is how De Beers can speak to Gen Z and Millennials without abandoning its heritage. If a diamond becomes a story, about time, love, the Earth or self-transformation, it regains its legitimacy.
- **It aligns with ethical expectations.** Meaning does not exclude responsibility; it integrates it. Sustainability, traceability and community impact must be told not as compliance, but as parts of a larger symbolic journey.
- **It repositions the brand.** De Beers must no longer sell just a product, but an experience of resonance, one that makes the buyer feel part of something greater than themselves.

4. *A new community: the symbolic hearth*

In the earliest epochs of *Homo sapiens*, a profound transformation unfolded: the emergence of symbolic thought. No longer limited to instinct or immediate survival, early humans began to construct abstract meaning, and with it, culture. This shift marked the beginning of a cognitive revolution: the capacity to imagine, to remember, to tell stories.

It was around the first sources of light, fires lit in the shelter of caves, that these early expressions took form. In the flickering half-light, individuals gathered to share narratives, not merely for warmth or safety, but for something immaterial yet vital. The storyteller emerged as a vessel of memory and imagination. With a voice that resonated through darkness, they recounted origins, cosmologies, cycles of life and death, forces of nature and unseen presences. These were not factual accounts. They were metaphysical structures, layered with symbolism, emotion and collective aspiration.

The stories carried by these early humans did more than entertain or explain. They unified the tribe, forged shared values, and provided psychic anchorage in a world of vast uncertainty. From these luminous circles were born the first myths, a fusion of dream, poetry and philosophical intuition. They emerged from the raw material of the human psyche, projecting meaning onto stone, sky, animal and flame. And it is no coincidence that some of the oldest symbolic artefacts we possess, among which the first ornaments, emerged alongside this cognitive flowering. These myths were not descriptive; they were transformative. They helped *Homo sapiens* transcend the here and now. They offered access to something beyond: time outside of time, truth beyond fact, beauty inseparable from mystery.

Today, in an age that is searching for connection, ritual and transcendence, it may be time to return, not to the caves, but to what they represent: the sacred space where symbol and story become the foundation of shared human meaning. As the diamond world faces mounting challenges, from shifting generational values and the rise of lab-grown diamonds to demands for transparency and sustainability and a deep erosion of trust, one imperative becomes clear. We must reawaken desire by reintroducing wonder, meaning and timeless storytelling.

To do so, we need to create and gather a strong, united community of natural diamond advocates, brought together through the revival of powerful mythologies and archetypal narratives that speak to the collective unconscious. These stories, anchored in symbolic thought and ancient rituals of gathering, would be shared by charismatic storytellers and guides, individuals who act as interpreters of meaning in an age of disconnection. These modern-day oracles would meet their audiences in contemporary sanctuaries: digital spaces of belonging designed for emotional resonance and intellectual engagement. Just as early *Homo sapiens* once sat around fires to transmit knowledge and forge shared values, this new community would gather around symbolic hearths to reimagine the role of natural diamonds, not merely as luxury objects, but as carriers of metaphysical significance, emotional heritage and intergenerational memory.

The creation of a community begins with trust, trust built through a known and recognised space, and through storytellers who are familiar, recurring figures. These storytellers, through a ritual rhythm, return time and again to guide their audience, offering immersive narratives infused with life and emotion. It is this consistency, of place, voice and rhythm, that establishes a sense of belonging. Over time, these shared moments become a kind of rite: a space where meaning is transmitted, where memory is shaped, and where a deeper connection to the natural diamond is forged.

5. The storytellers

To share this new narrative with a fresh community, it is essential to carefully select storytellers, experts in their respective fields, who can convey powerful and profound knowledge about natural diamonds. These guides should embody both depth and charisma, and be capable of inspiring trust and fascination through the themes they explore: geology, art history, gemmology, craftsmanship, myth and cultural meaning.

Equally crucial is their ability to speak meaningfully to audiences in the United States, India and China, not through generic messaging, but by rooting their discourse in culturally specific values, histories and emotional codes. The resonance of this narrative depends not just on what is said, but on

how and by whom it is told, with nuance, credibility and symbolic intelligence adapted to each cultural context.

SELECTION CRITERIA

- Be rooted in authentic cultural knowledge, whether academic, artistic or artisanal.
- Possess charisma and presence, able to embody and transmit emotion and trust.
- Bridge tradition and modernity, simplicity and intelligence, emotion and reason.
- Be able to speak across popular and intellectual registers, inspiring both admiration and understanding.

UNITED STATES: THE EMOTIONAL STORYTELLER AND CULTURAL REFRAMER

Dr Marisa Galvez, Stanford professor, specialist in medieval materiality and the poetics of stone and jewels.

Kimberly Drew (@museummammy), art curator and cultural communicator, bridging art, beauty and Black heritage.

Taffin (James de Givenchy), New York jewellery designer of French heritage, known for narrative-driven high jewellery.

Paul Greenberg, environmental journalist, able to bring ethical sourcing and geological storytelling into accessible terms.

Raven Smith, cultural commentator with wit and reach, ideal to create resonance across fashion, identity and symbolism.

RESONANCE THEMES. Desire and love, ethical awareness, re-enchantment of material culture, personal rituals, luxury as narrative.

INDIA: THE KEEPER OF SACRED AESTHETICS AND CRAFT TRADITIONS

Aditi Mangaldas, classical dancer and choreographer, who could speak symbolically about adornment, ritual and the body.

Rama Bijapurkar, consumer-behaviour expert, bridging tradition and modernity in the aspirations of the Indian middle and upper classes.

Pramod Kumar KG, heritage expert and curator, with profound knowledge of Indian jewellery traditions and their cultural context.

Mita Vashisht, actress and storyteller, known for narrating classical Indian epics and modern femininity with depth.

RESONANCE THEMES. The spiritual symbolism of stones, familial transmission, bridal narratives, ritual adornment, prosperity myths.

CHINA: THE CONNECTOR OF LEGACY, NATURE AND CONTEMPORARY MEANING

Hang Chunhui (杭春晖), jewellery historian and professor of design, specialist in material culture and cultural heritage.

Xu Bing (徐冰), conceptual artist whose work plays with language, perception and symbols; potential collaborator.

Sara Jane Ho, cultural etiquette expert, bridging East–West codes of beauty and refinement.

Zhang Yiyang, gemmologist and influencer with credibility in luxury jewellery circles, educated in both China and Europe.

Zhao Mengqi (赵梦琪), young poet and essayist weaving myth and personal history, ideal to lend modern emotional depth.

RESONANCE THEMES. Jade and stone symbolism, continuity, harmony between nature and form, respect for rarity and ritual.

PLATES · THE SYMBOLIC HEARTH



Chauvet-Pont-d'Arc cave, Ardèche: charcoal wall drawings, Aurignacian.



Mesopotamian cylinder seal impression.



The Flammarion engraving, 1888.



Catalan Atlas, 1375, detail: the legend of the Valley of Diamonds.



Map of the Kingdom of Golconda, detail.



Stonehenge, Wiltshire.

6. Rituals: narrative series by territory

Each territory receives three recurring series, carried by its own storytellers on the platforms where its aspirations are formed, so that formats differ while the rhythm of return remains the same.

UNITED STATES

Emotional resonance · ethical luxury · symbolic memory · modern identity

Fragments of Eternity

Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, Medium articles · Marisa Galvez, Taffin, Raven Smith

“Why do we long for permanence?” · “How do diamonds hold memory?” · “Can a stone speak of love?”

The Ethics of the Eternal

Carousel posts, live Instagram discussions · Paul Greenberg, a female gemmologist or designer from BIPOC communities

“Real versus synthetic: what is the emotional truth?” · “The deep time of natural origin” · “Why the Earth’s memory matters more than the lab”

Gem & Self

TikTok interviews, voiceover-led reels · Kimberly Drew, contemporary jewellers

“My first diamond: reclaiming rituals” · “Adornment and identity in American history”

INDIA

Sacredness · generational transmission · ritual beauty · ancestral knowledge

The Bridal Diamond: Rites of Passage

Instagram storytelling, long-form video · Aditi Mangaldas, Pramod Kumar KG

“The diamond as *shringar*: adorning the soul” · “How family jewels carry ancestral time” · “The diamond ritual, beyond marriage”

From the Earth to the Divine

Long-form Instagram posts, visual essays · gemmologists and designers working with temple heritage

“The *navaratna*: meaning of each stone” · “Diamonds in Indian mythology and cosmology” · “Why stone is sacred in Indian aesthetics”

Second Skin: The Ritual of Adornment

Pinterest boards, Reels · art historians, rural craft revivalists

“How Indian women wear stories” · “From birth to memory: when a jewel becomes part of the body”

CHINA

Harmony with nature · time and tradition · elegance · cultural symbolism

The Silent Stone: What Diamonds Remember

WeChat mini-articles, Xiaohongshu stories · Hang Chunhui, Xu Bing

“Diamonds as time capsules” · “What stones mean in Chinese heritage” · “What is eternal in Chinese aesthetics?”

Jade and Diamond: Dialogues of Purity

Visual pairings and short videos on Douyin · dual interviews with a gemmologist and a calligrapher

“The contrast between softness and light” · “How stones speak of values in Chinese culture” · “Adornment as refinement: silent luxury”

Across Generations

Family-based interviews on Weibo · multi-generational mother-daughter pairs

“What my grandmother taught me about beauty” · “Why we pass down symbols, not objects”

VII

From slogan to philosophy

Conclusion

What truly endures is not the material, but the meaning we give it.

Natural diamond crystal.



A Diamond is Forever is not a slogan. It is a philosophy, a worldview, rooted in the belief that what truly endures is not the material, but the meaning we give it. For millennia, humans have turned to rare and luminous stones not simply to adorn, but to remember, to transmit, to believe. The natural diamond is one of the Earth's oldest witnesses. Forged deep within its mantle and brought to light through time, it carries within it a fragment of the planet's own memory, made visible by human hands and meaningful through human stories.

The strategy set out in these pages reclaims this symbolic power. We no longer speak of diamonds as commodities. We speak of them as thresholds, between the personal and the universal, the material and the metaphysical, the transient and the eternal. In an era saturated with speed, noise and disposability, we return to ritual. We rebuild meaning through storytelling, not as entertainment but as transmission, across generations, cultures and continents. Through selected storytellers, guides across disciplines and geographies, we share the myths, sciences and gestures that reawaken a deeper connection to the diamond.

The platform exists to reignite desire, not as marketing but as cultural memory. To re-establish trust, not through persuasion but through presence. To speak not to consumers but to participants, those who gather around the shared symbolic fire of *A Diamond is Forever*. Something was lost along the way: aspiration became formula, luxury became noise, and the diamond, once a cosmic witness, a ritual object, a promise, became a product. The line written in 1947 survives that loss because it was never, in truth, about duration.

A diamond is not forever because it lasts. It is forever because it transcends. It is not what you own. It is what you inherit, what you pass on, what you choose to protect, in a world that forgets too fast.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Laura-Rachel Dubos di Fiorini is a creative and strategic director and an art and jewellery historian. She advises the leadership of major jewellery and gemmological Maisons, among them Cartier, De Beers and Chopard, and teaches at L'École des Arts Joailliers, Van Cleef & Arpels. This research was conducted for De Beers Group in 2025 as the strategic foundation of the *A Diamond is Forever* platform.

PRINCIPAL SOURCES

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ILLUSTRATIONS

De Beers advertising by N. W. Ayer & Son, 1940s–1990s; De Beers Group, Forevermark and Signet Jewelers campaigns, 2024; historical documents and works as captioned. Reproduced for the purposes of analysis.

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